Strange Addictions

By Laurie Allen

CAST OF CHARACTERS:

BETH *- addiction counselor*
MIKE *- obsessively calls his mom*
EARL *- collects toenails*
SUE *- thinks she is a cat*

INTRODUCTION

Reality TV shows premier all the time, and they actually get more shocking as time goes by. One popular show was My Strange Addiction *— a show that featured people who were absolutely hooked on things that the rest of us couldn't even begin to imagine. Whether it be an addition to puppets, balloons or getting plastic surgery, the show became a guilty pleasure for many fans.*

I guess I should confess now . . . I have a strange addiction too . . . I'm addicted to forensics/speech competitions. But rather than tell you about it . . . let me show you!

Strange Addictions by Laurie Allen

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

BETH: **(Pg 94 – 101)** Welcome. Welcome to Strange Addictions Anonymous. Here, you are free to share your most private and hidden addictions. And please, please be assured that you don't need to fear being misunderstood or judged, because here, we listen and support one another. No matter the addiction. Also, a quick reminder, absolutely no laughter or negative comments.

EARL: What about you? Are you addicted to anything?

BETH: Actually, yes. Thank you for asking. Exercise. Excessive exercise. To the point that it was once controlling my life. [But] I was able to set limits. Thirty minutes a day. Do I ever have stressful times and slip back into the excessive workouts to the point where I want to do jumping jacks for hours on end? Or worse yet, at inappropriate places? Say, a business meeting or a funeral?

MIKE: You did jumping jacks at a funeral?

BETH: *(Raises her hand)* Guilty. And that's why we're here, to acknowledge that we have a problem and then support and encourage each other as we work through our own

issues. So, let's begin. Who would like to go first?

MIKE: *(Halfway raises his hand)* Mike. I guess I can go.

BETH: So, tell us about your addiction, Mike.

MIKE: *(Quiet.)* Well, I... I call my mom. (Holds up his phone.) A lot . . . I like to hear her voice. Constantly. It's comforting, soothing, like when I was a baby.

SUE: Well, I call my mom four or five times a day, and that seems like a lot, but I don't think it's strange.

BETH: Mike, could you be more specific about how often you call her?

MIKE: I already told you. A lot. We hang up, and I call her again. And again. And again.

EARL: And she answers?

MIKE: Not always, but most of the time, yes, because if she doesn't I keep calling her. Again and again and again.

EARL: Oh, brother! What a ...

BETH: Now, now! No judging or name calling. We all have issues here that we are dealing with. We're here to help, support, and offer ideas to break these chains that are our addictions.

SUE: I have an idea. Why don't you tell your mom to get a new phone number and not tell you what it is?

EARL: *(Laughs.)* Yeah! I love that idea!

SUE: Then all you will hear is "We're sorry. You have reached a number that has been disconnected or is no longer in service."

MIKE: But what if I need my mom?

EARL: Then drive to her house and talk to her.

MIKE: She lives three hundred fifty miles away.

BETH: Mike, have you tried putting your phone away and limiting yourself to just one phone call per day?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MIKE: Tried it. It didn't work. *(Without thinking, calls his mom. Into phone.)* Hello, Mom ... I did. I'm here ... I know, Mom, but I can't do this without you ...

BETH: Mike, can you hang up now, please?

MIKE: I'm talking to my mom! *(Talks quieter.)* I got into trouble ... Okay, hold on ... *(To BETH.)* Mom wants to know why I'm in trouble.

BETH: You're not in trouble, Mike. It's just that we need to continue with our meeting, so, if you don't mind, can you call her back later?

MIKE: *(Into the phone.)* Did you hear that, Mom? ... Yeah. I have to hang up ... Okay. I'll call you back later. Love you. *(Hangs up.)*

BETH: Mike, can you please hand me your phone? I promise I'll give it back at the end of our session. Okay, who's next?

MIKE: No worries. I'll just put it right here. Out of sight, out of mind. *(Places the phone under his chair.)*

BETH: Okay, who's next?

SUE: *(Raises her hand.)* I guess me. I'm Sue..

BETH: Welcome, Sue. Tell us about your addiction.

SUE: Well, I have thirteen cats. There's Juliet, Bishop, Sophie, Lilly, Tom, Simba, Max, Whiskers, Tango, Iris, Snowball, Sugar, and Blackie.

BETH: Thirteen. Goodness. You must love your little fur babies a lot.

SUE: I do, but that's not the problem. I don't get out much so I... I mean, I mostly stay indoors with my cats. I don't like to leave them, and I... I feel like we're family, you know ... like we're connected ... (Suddenly begins meowing like a cat.) Meow, meow, meow...

EARL: What the heck? (Points.) She thinks she's a cat! (Claps.) That's hilarious!

SUE: Meow, meow, meow ... Do you have any treats? I like treats. Those little square ones are my favorite. You can toss a few on the ground, if you don't have a bowl.

EARL: This is hilarious!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

BETH: *(Snaps her fingers at EARL.)* Stop that! No negative talk!

MIKE: Is it true? You think you're a cat? Hold on! *(Takes a small snack out of his pocket and tosses it on the ground.)* Here, kitty, kitty, kitty ...

SUE: *(Excitedly jumps on the ground and sniffs the snack.)* Hey! These aren't the treats I like!

BETH: Sue, perhaps this is the first step for you. Getting out of your house and socializing with uh ... other humans.

SUE: *(Rubs against EARL'S leg.)* Meow.

EARL: Oh, my gosh! Make her stop! She's rubbing against me like a cat! Look here, lady, I don't like cats! In fact, I'm allergic to them! *(Sneezes. SUE hisses.)* Did you see that? She hissed at me!

MIKE: *(Grabs his phone and dials, unable to control himself. Into the phone.)* Mom, it's getting weird in here ... I know it's for strange addictions, but I shouldn't be here! Okay, I'll pay attention ... Love you too. *(Hangs up.)*

BETH: *(To EARL.)* Why don't we discuss why you're here? *(SUE hisses at EARL.)*

EARL: Can you make her stop hissing at me? Okay, well, I'm Earl.

BETH: Tell us about your addiction.

MIKE: Can I call my mom for a second?

BETH: No. Go ahead, Earl.

EARL: Toenails. I collect them. I mean, after I cut them, of course.

MIKE: Weird. I've got to tell my mom about this. *(Reaches for his phone.)*

BETH: No calls right now. *(MIKE FREEZES. It's killing him not to grab the phone.)*

EARL: Well, I started doing this when I was seven years old. I thought I'd make a toenail collection. Pretty cool, huh? So, I started putting them in this old tin box. That was twenty years ago. Man! You should see how many I have now! Wish I could sell them on eBay. Think they're worth anything?

BETH: Have you thought about throwing them in the trash?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

EARL: That's what my wife said. You sound kind of like my wife. But I said, "Heck no! Do you know how long I've been collecting my toenails?" And you know what she said? "It's either them or me!" So, either I throw them away, or she leaves me!

SUE: *(Smiles, purrs, and licks her hands.)*

EARL: *(Sneezes.)* I told you I'm allergic to cats!

MIKE: *(Grabs the phone and dials.)* Mom, these people are weird with a capital W. (Into the phone.) I don't know. Between the human cat and the toenail collector, I'm starting to freak out.

BETH: So, Earl, what do you love the most? Your old toenails or your wife?

EARL: And that's the question of the day. It's a hard decision for me. I mean, I love my toenail collection. And my friends, at least up to junior high, all thought my collection was cool!

BETH: Seriously? You don't know if you love your wife more than your clipped toenails? *(SUE swipes at EARL.)* Let's unpack this. Why did you start collecting your toenails?

EARL: Because it was fun! Oh, and I brought some of them - the toenails I've clipped while in therapy. *(Pulls out a plastic bag from his pocket.)* Want to see?

BETH: No! No! Please, no! I have a better idea. Let's imagine that your wife is here.

EARL: *(Sarcastic.)* Oh, great.

BETH: Put down the baggie and picture your wife sitting next to you. Now think. Think real hard. Who can you throw your arms around? Who can you kiss? Who makes you feel wonderful on the inside?

EARL: *(Grabs the plastic bag and holds it tightly.)* I'm keeping my toenails! *(Lifts the baggie and kisses it.)* I love you! I love you! I love you! *(SUE hisses and swipes him again. To SUE.)* Stop that! Bad kitty! Bad, bad kitty!

MIKE: *(Into the phone.)* Mom, this guy in here loves his toenails more than his wife.

BETH: Hang up the phone! Now!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

MIKE: Love you! *(Hangs up.)*

EARL: *(Takes off his shoes and socks, then pulls out clippers from his pocket.)* Let's just collect some more. Technically, this is group therapy, so they can still go in this bag. *(Cuts his toenails.)*

MIKE: *(Dials.)* Mom, I don't like it here. These people are strange. Mom, what are you doing? I miss you.

BETH: *(Jumps up.)* You people! I just don't know what to say! *(Begins doing jumping jacks.)* No one is listening to me! How can I help you if you won't listen to me? Do I care? Maybe I only care about myself! About getting into shape. Yes, that's what I care about!

EARL: *(Holds up a clipped toenail.)* Look at this one!

SUE: *(purrs loudly.)*

MIKE: *(Into the phone.)* Mom, I know it's a long drive, but can you come pick me up? I don't think this is working.

BETH: That's it, I'm out of here! *(Jogs OFF)*

EARL: Man, that is one strange lady!

(LIGHTS FADE to BLACK)

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Laurie Allen
Book: 22 Comedy Ten-Minutes Plays, Pg 94 - 101
ISBN: 978-1566082112
Publisher: Meriwether Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2019

AWARD HISTORY

2023 National Qualifier